the Intelligence Bureau. No one was willing to rock the boat by offering an opinion contrary to the top man's view. It was a classic case of the tail wagging the dog!

Not only did the IB paint for Nehru a highly exaggerated picture about the PLAAF's strike capability, it was downright dishonest in its overall appreciation. In March 1962, Lieutenant Liu Chengsze of the PLAAF defected to the USA in Formosa (Taiwan). He had earlier approached the Indians seeking political asylum, offering detailed information about the state of the Chinese air capabilities in exchange. The Indians had refused, but the Americans eagerly accepted the offer. However, the gist of Chengsze's information had been shared with the Indian Intelligence Bureau. According to the report, despite having over 2,000 aircraft at their disposal, the Chinese could only utilize a fraction of these against India from Tibet.

The main reason was the complete reliance on the Soviet Union for aviation fuel and spares. While it was true that the Chinese had used fighters and bombers to neutralize Tibetan resistance fighters in 1958, the quantum of aircraft used was miniscule. Subsequently, with Soviet aid drying up in 1960 after a chill in Sino-Soviet relations, the Chinese were hard-pressed to launch aircraft even in China, let alone Sinkiang and Tibet. Why the Intelligence Bureau chose to deliberately mislead the government and why the air chief failed to arrive at an independent assessment will remain another one of the unsolved mysteries of 1962.

On the other hand, the transport wing of the IAF played a major role not just during the operations but from the very beginning. In 1951 No. 11 Squadron was raised, flying Dakotas. At that point, there were already a number of Assam Rifles posts in NEFA, many of which had been completely cut off after the earthquake in 1950. As more and more forward posts were created, the demand for airlifting men and supplies began to escalate rapidly.

More squadrons were raised and in 1954, the first C-119 Packets arrived in India. However, the Packet was not designed for high altitude flying and there were a number of tragic accidents especially in Ladakh. Eventually, an additional engine (known as the jet pack) was fitted to the aircraft and Squadron Leader C. S. K. Raje went on to make aviation history by landing on the airstrip at Daulat Beg Oldi which is situated at 16,614 feet. In 1955, the Soviets presented Nehru with an IL-14 for his personal use, and then